Miyamoto Musashi

Human · Fighter (Battle Master) 20 · Rōnin · Shinmen Musashi-no-Kami Fujiwara no Genshin, c. 1584 – 13 June 1645: more than sixty duels without a loss, the two-sword school Niten Ichi-ryū, and the *Book of Five Rings*

Built on the 2024 rules from three sources, in this order. **History**: his own words in the *Book of Five Rings* and the *Dokkōdō* (both 1645), the monument his adopted son Iori raised at Kokura in 1654, and the later biographies, chiefly the *Niten Ki* of 1776, written more than a century after him and treated here as tradition, not record. **Yoshikawa Eiji's novel** *Musashi* (1935–39). **Inoue Takehiko's manga** *Vagabond* (1998 on; on hiatus since 2015, with Ganryūjima still undrawn). Where they disagree about what happened, history wins: Yoshioka Seijūrō survives his duel, as the monument says, though Inoue kills him. Where they only disagree about how much, the sheet takes the bigger number: the monument has him scatter the Yoshioka school at the spreading pine, Inoue has him kill seventy of them there, and the headline block can do the seventy.

Design calls. The headline block is Musashi at about fifty, the age at which he says he understood the Way; the famous duels were over before he was thirty, and they're in the snapshots. He's a man: point buy and a Fighter's feats, Strength 20 and no higher, no magic, no magic sword, and at 0 HP he's on the ground like anyone else. Everything past the Player's Handbook is one homebrew feature, **Niten Ichi-ryū**, in five parts after the five books of the *Five Rings*; nearly every line of it is something the book describes, with a rule attached. He's a Battle Master because the Water and Fire Books are lists of named techniques, and nine of them are his maneuvers. No armor: the duels are fought in ordinary clothes.

Snapshot: about fifty, the Way understood, level 20

Miyamoto Musashi

Medium Humanoid (Human) · plain clothes and no armor, the long sword in his right hand and the short one in his left · "Respect the Buddha and the gods without counting on their help." (Dokkōdō)

AC 16 (no armor: 10 + Dex + Wis), **22 against melee attacks** with both swords in hand · **HP** 204 (Tough) · **Speed** 30 ft · **Initiative** +9 with advantage (Alert; ken no sen) · **Proficiency** +6 · **Superiority dice** 6d12, DC 19, and a free d8 once on every turn (Relentless)

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)	8 (−1)

Saves Str +11, Con +8, Wis +9 (Resilient); Indomitable rerolls a failure at +20, three a day; advantage against being Charmed and against illusions; can't be Frightened · **Skills** Athletics +11, Acrobatics +9, Perception +9, Insight +9, Survival +9, History +7 · **Tools** calligrapher's, painter's, woodcarver's and smith's · **Languages** Japanese; reads classical Chinese

Defenses. The short sword receives. While it's in his hand, melee attacks are against AC 22, and its Reaction is **Parry** (a hit loses a superiority die + 5) or **Riposte** (a miss gets a cut back with the die on the damage). The long sword has a Reaction of its own, **Holding Down the Pillow**: when a melee attack hits him and isn't a critical, he cuts first at +13, and if that cut hits, the attack misses. From the third round he has the opponent's **rhythm**: its first attack at him each turn has disadvantage. Second Wind, 1d10+20, four a day. Nothing on the sheet brings him back from 0.

Attacks. Four per Attack action, the Nick cut and Dual Wielder's Bonus Action: six a turn, and Action Surge twice a short rest. **Katana** (+2): +13, 1d8+7 slashing, Sap. **Wakizashi** (+2): +13, 1d6+7 slashing, Nick. In the first round he has advantage against anyone who hasn't acted; from the third, on his first attack each turn. **Peerless Aim**: one miss a turn hits anyway. Studied Attacks: a miss gives advantage on the next. Slasher: a hit takes 10 ft of Speed, and a critical leaves the target attacking at disadvantage until his next turn. **One Cut**, once a short rest: a katana hit becomes a critical, ignores Resistance, and takes as many superiority dice as he likes.

Feats Alert (Rōnin), Tough (Human), Dual Wielder, Resilient (Wis), +2 Str, Slasher, +2 Wis, +1 Wis and +1 Dex, Boon of Combat Prowess · **Fighter 20** Two-Weapon Fighting, six masteries, Tactical Mind, Tactical Shift, Tactical Master, Studied Attacks · **Battle Master** nine maneuvers, Student of War, Know Your Enemy, Relentless · **Niten Ichi-ryū** (homebrew, next page)

How he fights. He takes the initiative and spends everything at once: Action Surge, ten cuts with advantage, and the One Cut on the first long-sword hit with all his dice but one. After that the short sword keeps the other weapon off him, the long sword cuts into whatever would have landed, and by the third round he has the timing. Against a bow or a gun he closes the distance, because he has nothing else.

Niten Ichi-ryū: the five rings

One homebrew feature in five parts, each named for a book of the *Five Rings* and gained at the level where the story reaches it (see the table). The technique names are the chapter headings of the Water and Fire Books.

Ground: Two Heavens as One

The Ground Book's argument: a warrior carries two swords, so train with one in each hand · unarmored AC from level 1, the rest at level 7

While he wears no armor his AC is 10 + Dex + Wis. While he holds a sword in each hand and isn't Incapacitated: he adds his Proficiency Bonus to his AC against melee attacks; the katana counts as Light for him, so Nick and Dual Wielder both apply and a turn is six attacks; and each sword has its own Reaction every round. The short sword's is for Parry and Riposte, the long sword's for Holding Down the Pillow or an Opportunity Attack. **The Ways of all professions** (a rule from the same book): he has four artisan's tools, and any length of wood in his hands is a sword. A wooden sword, a staff, a stick he was carving or an oar deals a sword's damage as bludgeoning, and he chooses whether it kills.

Water: the named cuts

Nine Battle Master maneuvers under the book's names

Parry is the smacking parry. **Riposte** is tai no sen, the initiative of waiting. **Precision Attack** is the two gazes, perceiving and seeing. **Disarming Attack** is the Red Leaves Cut, which knocks the other sword down. **Feinting Attack** is moving the shade. **Trip Attack** is causing loss of balance. **Menacing Attack** is frightening, with the three shouts. **Sweeping Attack** is the chapter called “there are many enemies”. **Pushing Attack** is the body strike.

Water: One Cut

Hitotsu no uchi · level 5 · once per Short Rest

When he hits with the katana, or with a wooden sword held like one, he can make it the One Cut. The hit is a Critical Hit, it ignores Resistance, and he can spend any number of superiority dice on it and add them all to the damage, doubled as a critical doubles them. At level 20 with five dice that is 2d8 + 10d12 + 7, about 80. Seijūrō went down to one blow of a wooden sword, and Kojirō to one blow of an oar.

Fire: the Three Initiatives

Ken no sen, tai no sen, tai-tai no sen · level 3

Ken no sen, attacking first: advantage on Initiative, and advantage on his attacks in the first round against any creature that hasn't acted yet. **Tai no sen**, waiting: Riposte. **Tai-tai no sen**, going in as the other comes in, is the Pillow below.

Fire: Holding Down the Pillow

Makura o osaeru: don't let the opponent's head rise · level 13 · the long sword's Reaction

When a creature hits him with a melee attack that isn't a Critical Hit, he can make one katana attack against it before the blow arrives, stepping up to 10 ft to reach it. If his attack hits, the creature's attack misses instead. The book describes stopping a cut at the first syllable of the word. One Cut can be used on this attack.

Fire: Rhythm

Hyōshi; the book says timing is in everything · level 17, “at about fifty”

From the third round of a fight he has its timing. The first attack each creature makes against him on each turn has disadvantage, and his own first attack on each of his turns has advantage.

Wind: the other schools

The Wind Book is his criticism of them, starting with the schools that trust an extra-long sword · level 11

He can use Know Your Enemy at will, and a Reach weapon doesn't keep him out: the step in Holding Down the Pillow and in Riposte carries him inside it.

Void: the Way of Walking Alone

Dokkōdō, twenty-one lines written seven days before he died · level 20

He can't be Frightened, and he has advantage on saving throws against being Charmed and against illusions. The Void Book is a page and a half about seeing what is there and nothing that isn't.

The swords

A katana and a wakizashi, each +2 · nothing magical

The katana is a longsword (1d8, Versatile 1d10, Sap) and the wakizashi a scimitar (1d6, Light, Nick). The +2 is a good smith and forty years in the same hands. Tradition attaches named blades to him, a Kaneshige and a Ryōkai most often; the sheet doesn't depend on which.

Build, level by level

Point buy 15 / 13 / 13 / 12 / 12 / 8 (Str, Dex, Con, Int, Wis, Cha). Rōnin is a custom background: +2 Str, +1 Con, Insight and Survival, calligrapher's supplies, Alert. Human: Tough. Ages are by the Japanese count he used himself, and every “where in the story” line says whose story it is.

Lvl	When	What you get	Where in the story, and whose
1	1596, age 13	Two-Weapon Fighting, Second Wind, masteries; Alert, Tough; unarmored AC	**History:** Arima Kihei of the Shintō-ryū, his first duel by his own account. Tradition adds that he threw the man down and beat him with a staff
2	1599, age 16	Action Surge, Tactical Mind	**History:** Akiyama of Tajima, "a strong martial artist", beaten. That one line of the *Five Rings* is all there is
3	1600	Battle Master: the smacking parry, tai no sen, loss of balance; the Three Initiatives	Sekigahara. The old account puts him with the losing Western army; newer research puts him in Kyūshū on the other side. **Yoshikawa, Inoue:** Takezō wakes up among the dead
4	1601–03	Dual Wielder (Str 18)	**Yoshikawa, Inoue:** hunted through the hills of Miyamoto, caught by the monk Takuan without a blow and hung from a tree. In the novel, three years shut in Himeji castle with books; he comes out as Miyamoto Musashi
5	1604, age 21	Extra Attack, Tactical Shift; One Cut	**History:** Kyoto. Yoshioka Seijūrō, head of the school that taught the Ashikaga shoguns: one blow of a wooden sword. He lives and gives up the sword. (Inoue kills him; history wins)
6	1604	Resilient (Wis)	**History:** Yoshioka Denshichirō comes with a five-foot wooden sword; Musashi takes it away and kills him with it. Yoshikawa and Inoue set it in the snow at the Sanjūsangen-dō
7	1604	Know Your Enemy; Red Leaves Cut, the body strike; Two Heavens as One	The spreading pine at Ichijōji. **History:** the school's men in their hundreds with swords and bows, scattered by one man. **Tradition:** he came early for once, killed the boy heir and cut his way out. **Inoue:** seventy men, all dead. Yoshikawa has him notice afterwards that he'd used both swords
8	1604–12	+2 Str (20)	Nara, the spearmen of the Hōzōin. **Tradition:** Okuzōin Dōei, beaten twice with a short wooden sword. **Inoue:** Inshun, and the first time Musashi runs for his life
9		Indomitable, Tactical Master	Fiction only, the Yagyū. **Yoshikawa:** a peony stem cut by old Sekishūsai that only Musashi can read. **Inoue:** the old man asleep, and Musashi unable to strike
10		Superiority d10; moving the shade, to frighten	**Tradition:** Shishido, the chain-and-sickle man of Iga; Musashi throws his short sword into his chest and follows it in. Yoshikawa calls him Baiken; Inoue gives the name to Tsujikaze Kōhei and lets him live
11		Three attacks; the Wind	**Tradition:** Musō Gonnosuke and his staff, beaten with a stick Musashi was carving, and let go. Gonnosuke's own school says he came back with a shorter staff and did better; nothing else says so
12		Slasher (Dex 14)	**History:** more than sixty duels between thirteen and twenty-eight or twenty-nine, none lost. His own count
13	1612, age 29	Studied Attacks; Holding Down the Pillow	**Tradition:** Ganryūjima, 13 April 1612. Sasaki Kojirō, the Drying Pole, and a wooden sword cut from an oar
14	1614–15	+2 Wis (15)	**History:** "at thirty I looked back": he decides the sixty wins weren't mastery. Osaka: the documents put him in Mizuno Katsunari's force, on the Tokugawa side
15	1620s	Relentless, six dice; there are many enemies, the two gazes	**History:** Himeji and Akashi. He lays out the town of Akashi, adopts Mikinosuke and then Iori. **Tradition:** beats Miyake Gunbei with two wooden swords
16	1632–34	+1 Wis (16), +1 Dex (15)	**History:** Kokura, with Iori, by now a senior retainer of the Ogasawara
17	about 1634	Action Surge (two), Indomitable (three); Rhythm	**History:** "at about fifty I understood the Way". The headline block
18	1638, age 55	Superiority d12	**History:** the siege of Shimabara. His own letter says a stone from the walls hit his shin and he couldn't stand
19	1640–41	Boon of Combat Prowess (Dex 16)	**History:** Kumamoto, as the guest of Hosokawa Tadatoshi. The Thirty-five Articles on strategy; the shrike on a dead branch, in ink
20	1643–45	Four attacks; the Way of Walking Alone	**History:** the cave called Reigandō. The *Book of Five Rings*, then the *Dokkōdō*, and seven days later, on 13 June 1645, he died

Snapshots by year, with the feats checked

Opponents are statted by feel against the 2024 Monster Manual: a school's rank and file as Guards (AC 16, 11 HP, +3 to hit), a named master as a CR 5–10 duelist. The checks say which source each feat comes from and whether the level can do it.

Shinmen Takezō

Harima and Mimasaka, 1596–1603 · Levels 1–4

Str 17, then 18 · **AC** 12 · **HP** 14 → 44 · one sword or a staff · Action Surge from 2, three maneuvers and four d8s from 3

The feat, checked. Arima Kihei was a travelling swordsman who had posted a challenge, and a thirteen-year-old took it up. A first-level fighter with Strength 17 against a CR 1 duelist is a fight he can win and might not, and Tough and Second Wind are how a boy gets through the first exchange. Nothing is recorded of what he did at Sekigahara and the sheet claims nothing. His one loss in these years is fiction and isn't a fight: Takuan talks him into a rope. Charisma 8, Wisdom 12.

Kyoto

The three Yoshioka duels, 1604 · Levels 5–7

AC 12, and 15 against melee from level 7 · **HP** 54 → 74 · two attacks, four with both swords · One Cut with four d8s, then five

The feat, checked. Seijūrō: the monument says one blow. An ordinary blow from a fifth-level fighter doesn't put a master down, and One Cut is the rule written to close that gap: a critical with every die, 2d8 + 8d8 + 4, about 49 from a wooden sword, which drops a CR 5 duelist outright or leaves him one touch from it. Denshichirō is an ordinary win. Ichijōji depends on whose it is. The tradition's version, kill the heir under the pine and cut a way out, is two rounds and a Dash for a seventh-level fighter. Inoue's seventy isn't: at level 7 he drops about two Guards a round and they wear through 74 HP long before the fortieth. The headline block can do it. Run through the arena's dice two hundred times, the level-20 sheet killed all seventy every time, in about thirteen rounds, for about 10 HP; with twenty of them shooting instead (the monument gives them bows), about 55. So the sheet stats the seventy as the bigger number the sources allow, and says plainly that it's the man of fifty who could do it, not the man of twenty-one.

The road

Nara, Iga, Edo, 1604–1612 · Levels 8–12

Str 20 · **AC** 12–13, and 16–17 against melee · **HP** 84 → 124 · three attacks from 11, five with both swords · seven maneuvers, d10s

The feat, checked. Three weapons that out-reach a sword, and the traditions give him a different answer to each. Against the Hōzōin spear he goes in with a short wooden sword, inside the point, twice: Feinting Attack and the body strike. Against the chain and sickle he throws the short sword before the chain is moving, which is ken no sen and an improvised throw. Against Gonnosuke's staff he uses a stick and doesn't hurt him, which is “any wood is a sword” and choosing not to kill. Inoue adds what history doesn't have: a first meeting with Inshun where Musashi is outclassed and runs. Level 8 against a CR 9 prodigy with Reach goes that way on these numbers too. Both fictions make the Yagyū chapters about the Wisdom he doesn't have yet (13): the best swordsman he meets is an old man who won't fight him.

Ganryūjima

Funashima, 13 April 1612. The date and most of the detail are the Niten Ki's, 164 years later · Level 13

AC 13, and 18 against melee · **HP** 134 · three attacks · five d10s · Holding Down the Pillow · the oar: a wooden sword cut longer than the Drying Pole, held in both hands, 1d10+5 bludgeoning, reach 10 ft

The feat, checked. Sasaki Kojirō, called Ganryū: a master with a blade over three feet long and a cut named for the swallow, so a CR 9–10 duelist with Reach. The tradition's fight is one exchange. Kojirō's cut takes off Musashi's headband and the oar comes down on his head in the same moment; a second blow to the ribs ends it. That is Holding Down the Pillow with One Cut on the Reaction: Musashi's attack lands first, Kojirō's hit becomes a miss by the width of a headband, and 2d10 + 10d10 + 5, about 71, goes into the oar. The second blow is his next turn. Arriving late on purpose is the Niten Ki's story (the monument says they arrived together), and in 5e it's advantage on Initiative. Yoshikawa ends his novel on this beach. Inoue hasn't drawn it.

The years of service

Osaka, Himeji, Akashi, Kokura, Shimabara, 1614–1638 · Levels 14–18

Wis 16 by level 16 · **AC** 14–15, and 19–21 against melee · **HP** 144 → 184 · Relentless, six dice, d12s at 18 · Rhythm at 17

The feat, checked. Two sieges and no duels to the death. At Shimabara a stone thrown from the walls hit his shin and put him on the ground, by his own letter, and the sheet keeps that: the guard is against a weapon in someone's hand, AC 21, and against anything thrown or shot he's a man in a kimono, AC 15. In the arena that's why Adam Smasher beats him every time and Arthur Morgan one time in three. The duels of these years, like Miyake Gunbei's at Himeji, end with the other man alive: a Battle Master choosing to knock out.

The cave

Kumamoto and Reigandō, 1640–1645 · Levels 19–20

The headline block: AC 16 and 22, 204 HP, six attacks, the five rings

The feat, checked. He was about sixty and finished with fighting, so the headline block is the swordsman of fifty with the understanding of sixty; the sheet doesn't age him. In the arena on these sheets he wins about half his fights. He beats everyone whose answer is a weapon in the hand: Jin Sakai, Guts, Kyle Crane and Talion at least four times in five, V and Arthur about two in three, Spike and Goblin Slayer every time. He beats Itachi nineteen times in twenty, because the Tsukuyomi has to get through Wisdom +9 with advantage and three Indomitables at +20, and he's across the sand before the second try. He loses to what doesn't stay down or can't be reached: the Slayer, Link, Anderson and Smasher every time, Might Guy all but once in forty, Kratos seven times in eight, Battle Beast three in four.

A DM's dial

Three knobs, the most generous first. **The guard.** Six more AC against melee, all the time, is the biggest thing on the sheet. The Player's Handbook version is Defensive Duelist: the same +6, for a Reaction, on one attack. **Holding Down the Pillow.** A free attack that can cancel a hit every round is strong; charge a superiority die for it and it becomes a choice. **One Cut.** Cap it at three dice, or drop the line about Resistance, and it's a big critical instead of a duel-ender. The first draft of this sheet was the Player's Handbook alone, with none of the three: it lost to Guts nine times in ten and to nearly everyone above Jin, which is a fair reading of a man with two swords and no armor, and not what any of the three sources describe. What wasn't turned up: his Strength, his speed, his hit points, and anything that would let him cut what a sword can't cut.